

Creating the Ho Chi Minh Trail

The North Vietnamese decided to create the Ho Chi Minh Trail as a means of infiltrating South Vietnam. It proved to be one of their greatest assets. During the course of the war more than one million Viet Cong and North Vietnamese soldiers used its network of tracks.

◀◀ BEFORE

The men and women who built and used the Ho Chi Minh Trail followed in the footsteps of tribal hunters and the Viet Minh.

TRIBAL HUNTING PATHS

During the **First Indochina War** against the French, Ho Chi Minh dispatched an entire division along the tribal hunting paths that were later to become the backbone of the Ho Chi Minh Trail.

In 1954, General Vo Nguyen Giap, the Viet Minh's commander in the war, also used little-known tracks and trails to get his 55,000-strong army, plus its supporting artillery, into position for the **Battle of Dien Bien Phu**, which ended French colonialism in Southeast Asia.

Colonel Vo Bam, a logistics expert working in the Ministry of Defense in Hanoi, masterminded the creation of the supply route known as the Ho Chi Minh Trail. His watchwords were “absolute secrecy, absolute security.” His initial plan was for North Vietnamese infiltrators to make their way stealthily through the narrow demilitarized zone (DMZ) between North and South Vietnam, and then follow Route Nine, the road linking the Vietnamese coastal plain with the Mekong Valley, to join Viet Cong detachments at jungle staging posts south of Khe Sanh.

The proposed route was practical, but also risky. When the South Vietnamese Army (ARVN), which regularly patrolled Route Nine, realized what was going on, it sent reinforcements to Khe Sanh and began clearing the area. Bam was forced to reconsider his plan. He concluded that the DMZ could be avoided by rerouting the trail down the western side of the Truong Son mountains and through lower Laos. Both Hanoi and the Pathet Lao, the communist insurgents in Laos, approved the new route. The Royal Laotian Army put up little opposition.

At the same time, a maritime infiltration route was established. Less well-known than the Ho Chi Minh Trail, it proved crucial to supplying Viet Cong insurgents in the far south of the country.